

Meeting Script: The Architecture of Self-Honesty

Total Duration: 45 Minutes

Structure: 10-Min Intro → 20-Min Guided Meditation → 30-Min Teaching & Inquiry

Part 1: Introduction – The Architecture of Self-Honesty [10 Minutes]

"Welcome to the Living Mindfully Meditation Group.

[IF NO ONE IS NEW]

If this is our first time meeting - Hello and Welcome! I look forward to hopefully getting to know you better and it is my truest wish that you will find this group helpful, supportive and inclusive.

Before we start some housekeeping.

It is my intention to make this an on-going weekly meeting and to hold the meeting for 90 minutes..

I originally only allocated an hour but today and in the future I intend to hold it for 90 minutes. This is the length my previous groups were and this gives us time for meditation, some form of a teaching, and a period of time to discuss. If you have to leave early that is okay but I hope you can be a bit flexible so we can have some discussion.

I welcome any feedback that you care to provide regarding any of this, our time of day or length, suggestions on the subject matter we address, or any other input you wish to share. This is an open invitation.

You can send me a message via the website, HeadHeartTogether.com, or DM me on Facebook. I am really open to any method you choose. Let me know if you need any information on that.

And finally, a land acknowledgement. I am currently here on what has been traditional Ohlone Coast Miwok territory. The reason we do this is to formally recognize and honor the indigenous communities who originally stewarded the land where this virtual meeting is taking place. I extend that welcome to you from wherever you are and your perspective environment.

Any questions so far?

(PAUSE)

Arriving

Now that we have gotten thru the preliminaries. Why don't we take a moment to arrive?

Settling into the body, noticing your posture, letting go of the outside world, and simply taking a couple of conscious breaths. Coming into the present together.

(PAUSE)

Tonight, we gather to explore what I call the 'The Architecture of Self-Honesty.' Having joined together in community as fellow travelers on the path—to look at ourselves honestly, to be willing to look clearly at the architecture of your own minds and away from the stories we tell ourselves and towards the raw, direct experience of the present moment in an honest manner."

"We often perceive reality through a 'lens of bias.' As the Stoics taught, we do not see the world as it is, **but as we are**. These lenses are sculpted by our conditioning—our past trauma, familial patterns, and societal 'hats' we wear to navigate the world."

Self-honesty is the courageous act of looking at and working to set these lenses aside. Spiritual practice

Is an invitation to shift our energy away from a strictly outward analysis and move that inwards towards an internal investigation. We are here to contemplate and investigate the protective stories that obscure us from seeing the whole truth and not just what we want to see or maybe not look at ."

So we are invited from an external dialog to an internal one. As the Zen master Thich Nhat Hanh often reminded us, "every word we speak has a spirit; when we speak a word, we share its spirit with others.

Tonight, as we look at the architecture of our own honesty, remembering that our speech is not merely information—it is the manifestation of our state of mind. We are moving from speech that 'dumps' our internal state on others to speech that is mindful, deliberate, and aligned with our deepest values."

Part 2: Somatic Meditation – Dropping the Story [20 Minutes]

Guided Practice

So with this framework we will enter a period of meditation. A bell sound at the end at approximately the bottom of the hour.

So settling to our meditation posture. Getting comfortable as we can. No need to sit cross-legged. If you need to, you can lie down as long as you remember that your intention here is to be wakeful and not to sleep. And If you are sleepy, it might be helpful maybe to do standing meditation or as we go take in some deep in-breaths. Otherwise breathing normally.

However you wish to practice -
So allow your eyes to close.

Maybe taking a moment as you come into stillness to gently sweep the awareness through the body, letting go of any areas of obvious tightness or tension.

Keeping your attention inward to the physical body:
Noticing the feeling the weight of the body,
contact with your butt on the cushion
Your feet on the floor,

and as we settle into the body becoming aware of this rhythm of the breath.

Staying with this natural rhythm of breathing

Not grabbing the breath.

Not wishing the breath to be any other way.

Just natural breathing.

(After a minute or so)

You might notice sensations, tingling, tension, or tightness,
Noticing feelings, (unpleasant feelings or pleasant feelings)
Or you might notice you are experiencing a particular mood.
May thoughts, thinking.

Not grasping onto any of this. Noticing, observing, watching.

Noticing all of this arising seemingly from nowhere.
New experiences arising and the previous experiences disappearing

Notice if there is any storyline or ongoing narrative.
Observing them as if they're just clouds passing by.

Not grasping or clinging.

Simply knowing this experience - in this moment.

And if you realize you have been captured.
This is good. This is what it means to be mindful

Staying with this awareness and gently returning to the breath
Over and over again. Coming back into presence.

[bottom of the hour, concluded by a bell]

SHORT BREAK

Part 3: The Architecture of Self-Honesty (Teaching & Inquiry)

As we proceed to the main part of our meeting, it is valuable to remember that our approach is grounded in spiritual principles.

There are a few truths that we should keep in mind as we talk about honesty are:

- The first is the understanding that how we see the world is in fact the world to us. We do not know it any other way.
- The function of the mind is to pick and choose what to process out of all of what we experience.
- So the mind is always looking for something to process - to look at. This includes all that comes into our senses: seeing, hearing, tasting, touching, feeling, and also, in Buddhist terms, thinking. We cannot sense anything otherwise.
- So to one degree or another, the mind prioritizes things that we can eat or is threatening us or we can mate with. This is instinctual to be human and actually most of all life.
- And this is not necessarily personal to us even though we are the ones experiencing it.
- And lastly, once the mind picks up a thought. It has a tendency to proliferate on that.
- Notice this as we move along. We can be mindful of these aspects of being human.

Given this we can start to look at the Architecture of Honesty - and narrowing down to self-honesty in particular.

1. Defining Honesty: Satya, Wise Speech, and the Nature of Truth

Honesty is a core moral virtue characterized by truthfulness, sincerity, and integrity.

Honesty is believed to be a fundamental value in American culture, deeply rooted in historical, religious, and political traditions. While this ideal of a complete and uncompromising "honesty" exists, the practical application is often nuanced and situational.

For instance, the American legal system is predicated on honesty and having ethical codes of conduct. But, as can be seen clearly today, and probably never in human history, has the application of the legal system always met these ideals.

Overall, we have this view of ourselves that is not entirely honest and truthful. An example of this in liberal areas is where we believe that we should house the homeless, but we don't necessarily want them living in our backyard or in our neighborhoods.

Another example that I run into frequently is where people will say that they are going to attend the meeting, this meeting, be it the past meetings we've had or the current one, but most people hardly ever show up. The idea of attending the meeting but then when it actually comes up to take action, other considerations get in the way. I'm not faulting anybody because this happens to me too.

I'll speak to this a little bit more later.

Another ideal relating to honesty is of being direct and straightforward and not avoiding deception. But the fact is that - most of the time - what we're doing as we talk to other is to inject our beliefs into them to get them to agree, to impress them, or to win an argument. We endlessly debate what is truth and what is fact, with truth being rewritten all the time.

What is taught is not the whole truth. We pick and choose our history. Therefore it is not completely honest. Truly being honest calls on us to look at all the facts, whether we like them or not, and to know is true.

We can genuinely not know that we are deceiving ourselves and this is due to our own particular biases and conditioning.

What one person sees is different from what another person sees, depending on their perspective or, as I like to say, the "hat" or particular the lens that they are viewing through. In many ways the legal system has actually started to depend less on people's testimonies as a result of this.

So there is a lot of self-deception due to these cognitive biases.

And then there is the social etiquette of being polite and in avoiding harm. Many people avoid conflict externally or within themselves. Any many people find privacy and confidentiality of utmost importance. This is not necessarily honest.

And there are things that people don't want us to know. Our personal truths that we're not proud of.

And lastly, on a societal level, there is the whole world of marketing, advertising and business interests, which uses persuasive techniques that push the boundaries of strict truthfulness all the time. The same technique is used in multimedia and the news to sensationalize things to

draw interest. Companies are constantly pushing the boundary of fair value and excessive profit. This is dishonest.

Globally the top 1% of adults hold roughly 38% to 47% of the world's total net wealth. 10% hold approximately 85% of the world's total wealth and the bottom 90% share the remaining 15% of global wealth, with the poorest half of the world's population holding barely 1%. In many ways fairness and honesty are tied together.

And even in the world of religion, we see people who claim to believe certain things and yet act not in accordance with those things. Not being truthful to their religion. Again, coming from this distorted lens.

So overall, in Western culture in particular, we grapple with the complex relationship between honesty and other values, such as loyalty, compassion, and the pursuit of individual and collective goals.

Ideally, overall Honesty involves a refusal to lie, deceive, or steal, as well as a commitment to presenting yourself authentically to the world.

Acting honestly aligns our words with reality with our actions, and strengthens trust in all of our relationships.

The Dimensions of Honesty

Understanding honesty requires looking at it through a few distinct lenses:

Truthfulness vs. Deception:

- So as I mentioned, at its simplest, being honest means not lying or withholding the truth for personal gain.
- **Integrity:** This goes beyond just words. It means being a person whose actions, values, and principles remain consistent, regardless of who is watching.
- **Self-Honesty:** Self-Honesty is the ability to be completely real with yourself about your own feelings, flaws, and motivations.

Why does Honesty Matter?

So why does Honesty Matter”

- It provides a Foundation of Trust: Strong relationships, whether personal, professional, or societal, rely heavily on the assumption that you can depend on what others say and do..
- Honesty affects our Mental Health: Deception requires a great deal of mental effort and can trigger stress responses in the body.
- Practicing honesty promotes mental well-being and confidence.
- And honesty promotes Authenticity: Speaking and acting without pretense helps you live an intentional life that aligns with your actual values.

How do spiritual traditions look at Honesty?

- There is Indigenous Truth-Listening: Traditions like the A-nishin-aabe (the Seven Sacred Teachings) and Aboriginal Australian perspectives teach "truth-listening"—hearing uncomfortable realities about history and our own impact with openness instead of defensiveness.
- **There is Satya (Truth/Correctness):** In Indic traditions, honesty is *Satya*—the alignment of mind, speech, and action with reality. It is not merely avoiding lies, but living in accordance with the truth of the present moment.
- **There is Wise Speech (Right Speech):** Honesty requires a commitment to speech that is not only factually true, but also helpful, kind, and timely. We practice *Wise Speech* by abstaining from idle chatter, harsh language, and divisive gossip, recognizing that every word carries the "spirit" of our mind.
- **And there is the Relative vs. Absolute Truth:** We distinguish between subjective perceptions (our "lenses" of trauma and conditioning) **and** the underlying reality. Spiritual honesty is the courage to identify our biases and set them aside, rather than mistaking them for objective truth.
- Overall, this promotes the bliss of blamelessness. Not worrying about whether or not you are honest, truthful, and kind promotes a freedom of well-being that guarantees happiness.

2. The Architecture of Deception: Society & "The Committee"

(pause)

1. **The Modern Challenge:** We face a crisis where intellectualism and truth is challenged by polarization and misinformation.
 - Digital connectivity has accelerated the "cognitive tax" of managing complex, fabricated narratives.
 - In society, we feel how this foundation of trust has been breached. And with the rise of AI, we have power tools for people to deceive, cheat or otherwise be dishonest.
2. White Lies
 - And then there are white lies, also known as fibbing. These are thought of as small, harmless lies told with supposed good intentions.
 - They are commonly used as a part of the "social glue" of daily life.

- We tell them to protect someone's feelings or keep the peace, or to make them or ourselves feel good..
- They bend the truth.
- They are not necessarily meant to trick or harm anyone.
- Think of the truth like a "sharp knife". You can use it to slice food to share, but you can also use it to cut someone. White lies are the safety guard for the knife. They let you hand the knife to someone safely.
- But we need to be careful about this. For when we use white lies we are being untruthful.
- This is where mindfulness can help to look at our intentions and understand the impact they have on ourselves and others.
- They can seem harmless but can easily erode the foundation of honesty and truth within us.
- Buddhism calls us to avoid any false speech at all. It is better to be silent.

3. Psychology & Neuroscience: The "Cognitive Tax"

- **The Brain's Default:** Yet, according to Neuroscience, Honesty is the brain's baseline.
- Dishonesty is resource-heavy, forcing the Prefrontal Cortex to manage the truth and the lie simultaneously, creating a "cognitive tax."
- **Amygdala Desensitization:** Research shows that while the first lie triggers guilt, repeated deception desensitizes the amygdala (the brain's "emotional braking system"), making future lies easier and eroding our internal compass. This is why I mentioned why white lies are so dangerous.

To successfully pull off a lie, the brain must execute three resource-heavy steps:

1. **Inhibition:** It must actively suppress the automatic urge to tell the truth.
 2. **Fabrication:** It must construct a plausible, internally consistent alternative narrative.
 3. **Mentalizing (Theory of Mind):** It must constantly calculate what the *other* person knows, thinks, or suspects to ensure the lie remains believable to them.
- **The Somatic Toll:** But the karmic impact of dishonesty splits our experience, leading to muscle tension, shallow breathing, and systemic fatigue. Alignment, by contrast, reduces sympathetic nervous system activation, bringing us back to physical safety.

1. So why do we lie?

- Occasionally we lie to avoid the fear of consequences. I saw this with my children, especially as teenagers when they were growing up.
- Being Honest can be a difficult thing to do.

2. The "Fudge Factor" and Self-Concept

Psychologist Dan Ariely pioneered research into everyday dishonesty, establishing that most people want to look at themselves in the mirror and feel like a good, honest person. However, they also want to benefit from minor deceptions.

- To balance this, humans utilize a psychological "**fudge factor.**"
- We cheat just enough to gain an advantage (convenience, status, and avoiding discomfort) but keep the infraction small enough that our psychological defense mechanisms can rationalize it away.

3. Common Psychological Catalysts

In alignment with human behavior patterns, psychology categorizes the primary drivers of everyday dishonesty into distinct protective buckets:

- **Impulse for Convenience:** Fabricating small stories to avoid immediate friction, awkwardness, or minor accountability.
- **Defense of Status and Armor:** Exaggerating achievements or withholding failures to protect an idealized identity, reputation, or social standing.
- **Aversion to Discomfort:** Lying or omitting truth out of fear—either fear of vulnerability, fear of conflict, or a deeply ingrained habit-energy of avoiding emotional discomfort often rooted in past conditioning or trauma.

4. The Somatic Toll: The Cost of Living a Divided Life

Psychologically and physiologically, chronic dishonesty splits a person's lived experience into two conflicting realities: the truth they inhabit and the mask they present.

- **Chronic Stress Elevation:** Because maintaining a deception requires continuous monitoring, it keeps the sympathetic nervous system subtly activated. This chronic "high-alert" status can manifest somatically as muscle tension, shallow breathing, and systemic fatigue.
- **The Gift of Alignment:** Conversely, practicing radical honesty acts as a neurological unburdening. When internal felt-sense experience matches external expression, the brain drops the cognitive tax of monitoring contradictions. This alignment shifts the nervous system out of defense mode and into a state of psychological safety, resilience, and genuine well-being.

4. The "Committee" of the Mind

1. Internal Dialog: Our internal dialogue is often hijacked by competing sub-personalities—
 - a. the "Driver of Convenience,
 - b. " the "Defender of Status,"
 - c. and the "Voice of Self-Judgment."

- d. These are what Buddhists call *hindrances*. Recognizing these voices as a "committee" rather than "us" allows us to stop being pushed and pulled by conflicting internal agendas.
2. Thanissaro Bhikkhu, one of my favorite teachers, uses the term "the committee" to describe the fragmented and often conflicting nature of our internal dialogue.
 - a. This concept highlights that the mind is not a single, unified entity but rather a collection of different "voices" or sub-personalities, each with its own desires, agendas, and conditioned habits.
 - b. There are some Key Characteristics of the Committee:
 - i. Internal Conflict: Different parts of the "committee" often want contradictory things. For example, one part may recognize a thought as unskillful, while another part "really likes" it and wants to indulge in it.
 - ii. Habitual Conditioning: Much of this internal activity is conditioned by past experiences and can become a deeply ingrained habit, leading to a constant "battle in the mind".
 - iii. Background Chatter: This committee is responsible for the "background chatter" of verbal fabrication—the constant stream of talking to ourselves, asking questions, and making comments.

From the Buddhist point of view virtues such as honesty are foundational and is explicitly categorized within the ethical framework of **Moral Discipline**.

It is not just about telling the truth to others; it is equally focused on **radical self-honesty**—the willingness to see your own mind, motives, and reactivity clearly without fabrication.

Within the foundational Buddhist teachings there are

1. Within the Five Precepts (Lay Ethical Code)

The Five Precepts. The basic code of ethics for Buddhist laypeople. Honesty is the explicit focus of the **Fourth Precept**, which is to "undertake the training rule to abstain from false speech."

- **The Commitment:** This is a commitment to abstain not only from deliberate lying but also from deceit, exaggeration, and acting in a way that creates a false impression. It encourages reliability, trustworthiness, and being "true to one's word."

2. Within the Noble Eightfold Path (The Path to Enlightenment)

Within the Noble Eightfold Path, the core summary of the Buddhist path of practice. Honesty is directly located within **Right Speech** (*Sammā Vācā*), which is one of the three components of the Śīla (Virtue) division of the path.

Right Speech is traditionally defined by four abstentions:

1. **Abstaining from Lying** (*Musāvāda*): Speaking only what is true and factual.

2. **Abstaining from Slandorous/Divisive Speech** (*Pisunāya vācāya*): Not repeating gossip to cause discord; speaking to unite.
3. **Abstaining from Harsh Speech** (*Pharusāya vācāya*): Abstaining from anger-driven, rude, or abusive language; speaking gently.
4. **Abstaining from Idle Chatter** (*Samphappalāpa*): Not engaging in pointless or frivolous talk; speaking meaningfully.

Therefore, "honesty" in Buddhism includes being factual (not lying), but it also demands that the truth must be spoken at the right time, with goodwill, and in a way that is beneficial, not harmful.

3. The Underlying Virtue: Self-Honesty

Beyond specific rules of speech, many teachers emphasize that **radical self-honesty** is the most vital spiritual virtue.

Without the honesty to face your own mental states—like jealousy, anger, or greed—without pretense, you cannot practice mindfulness or develop compassion. You must be willing to see "things just as they are" within your own mind before you can unburden your heart.

(jump down to [Honesty](#))

2. Radical Internal Honesty: Inquiry and the "One Who Knows"

3. Radical Honesty

- **Self-Inventory:** [Honesty](#) is foundational for survival in recovery and for spiritual growth of any kind. It begins with the rigorous practice of taking an inventory—turning toward the parts of ourselves we usually dissociate from.
- **The Power of Speaking Truth:** Sometimes it is not enough to hold the truth internally. The act of speaking our inventory to another person can shatter the isolation of the "committee" and release the shame that thrives in secrecy. I refer to this frequently as "shining the light".
 - Families and societies commonly avoid shining a light on things so that they can avoid or hide the things that they're not proud of.
 - Many times with isolation, holding things internally leads to the creation of manifestos, and going down a wrong path.
 - So this is where spiritual friendship and trust are helpful.
- **Strategic Use of the Committee**
 - a. Thanissaro Bhikkhu emphasizes that in meditation and to live mindfully this is not a passive practice of merely watching this chatter BUT THIS CAN BE HELPFUL. As I just mentioned, bouncing our thoughts and feelings off another spiritual friend can be greatly helpful. But he suggests a more active approach to manage the committee:

- i. **Developing "The Watcher"**: By intentionally sitting and observing the mind, you create a new, skillful identity within the committee: **the watcher** or **inner observer**. Making this identity as solid as possible serves as a "Gatekeeper" that helps us navigate internal conflicts and misunderstandings.
 - ii. **Watching with Purpose**: When unskillful thoughts arise that the mind refuses to let go of, the "watcher" is tasked with observing them to understand their source. The goal is to figure out where that part of the mind is being deluded and to see the "ridiculous" nature of unskillful indulgent views.
 - iii. **Deploying Fabrication**: In the internal battle against unskillful thoughts, you can use specific "tools" or "weapons" of fabrication to retrain the committee
- b. He speaks of three types of fabrication:
- i. Bodily Fabrication: Using the breath to anchor the mind.
 - ii. Verbal Fabrication: Using directed thought and evaluation to talk to yourself in a more skillful way.
 - iii. Mental Fabrication: Adjusting the perceptions (the labels) and feeling tones you apply to experiences.

In our mindfulness practice, healing is predicated on *Ehipassiko*—the invitation to "come and see for yourself." This is not a request for belief, but a radical **rejection of dogma** in favor of direct experience.

We cannot find freedom without a willingness to look honestly at the nature of reality, stripped of our habitual defenses.

Inquiry is like shining a light into a dark room; if we do not look, we continue to bump into the furniture of our own conditioning -- confused and hurt.

Many of our internal patterns are like frightened creatures that take refuge in the darkness of the "unseen."

The mechanism for this internal honesty is **Mindful Investigation**. We must be willing to turn toward the parts of ourselves we have dissociated from, asking the diagnostic question that cuts through the trance:

"What are you unwilling to feel?"

To deconstruct our internal narratives, we can practice a rigorous **Mindfulness of Thoughts**, labeling mental events to see them for what they are:

Eventually, this practice leads to the profound insight of **non-identification**. When we recognize a thought is "just a thought" rather than a fact, we shift from being the "scared self" to being the "One Who Knows"—the spacious, mindful presence.

This is the highest form of internal honesty.

Without this internal clarity, we remain trapped in the "trance of unworthiness," making it impossible to navigate the complexities of our social positioning and multicultural relationships with true integrity.

4. Benefits of Honest Living: Freedom & Health

So what are the benefits of Honest Living.

- **Inner Peace and Clarity:** Exploring how to practice being honest can lead to a sense of inner freedom, and clarity of mind. .
- **Strengthened Relationships:** Honesty builds trust, fosters deeper connections, and creates a supportive environment. Trust is the byproduct of radical integrity.
- **Spiritual Growth:** Adhering to truth accelerates spiritual progress, deepens self-awareness, and aligns us with our higher self.
- **The Bliss of Blamelessness:** The Buddha famously never lied; this points to the psychological freedom of having nothing to hide and no internal "war" against reality.
- **Freedom:** When our intentions are clear and rooted in kindness, external criticism loses its power. As the Dalai Lama teaches, knowing our own good intention is the ultimate shield.

I CAN STOP HERE.

Part 4: Summary and Questions [15 Minutes]

1. Final Synthesis: Honesty as the Portal to Freedom

Honesty is the practice of "absolute cooperation with the inevitable." By refusing to argue with the truth of our experience, we move from the fleeting, conditioned happiness to the unconditioned lasting space of happiness.

The ultimate form of honesty is the **willingness to be uncertain**.

To maintain internal integrity and honesty, we must put down our need to be the authority who knows and instead enter the moment open-handed.

I invite you to embrace the spirit of *Ehipassiko*: do not take these principles as dogma.

Investigate your own heart.

By seeing the truth of your own mind, you open the portal to a freedom that no condition can take away. **Come and see for yourself and enjoy the benefits.**